

Introducing the Old English Set Texts 3: *The Wanderer*

[1] The Exeter Book (Exeter Cathedral Library MS 3501) Contents:

- Christ I, II (signed by Cynewulf) & III; Guthlac A & B
- Azarias; The Phoenix; Juliana (signed by Cynewulf); The Wanderer; The Gifts of Men; Precepts; The Seafarer; Vainglory; Widsith; The Fortunes of Men; Maxims I; The Order of the World (aka The Wonder of Creation); The Rhyming Poem; The Panther; The Whale; The Partridge
- Soul and Body II; Deor; Wulf and Eadwacer; Riddles 1–59; The Wife's Lament; Judgement Day I; Resignation; The Descent into Hell; Alms-Giving; Pharaoh; The Lord's Prayer I; Homiletic Fragment II; Riddle 30b; Riddle 60; The Husband's Message; The Ruin; Riddles 61–95

Digital version: <https://theexeterbook.exeter.ac.uk/index.html>

[2] The structure of *The Wanderer*

- 1–5: an exile waits for a lord/God's mercy, wandering in exile, at sea
- 6–29a: an *eard-stapa* recalls the loss of friends, lord and kin in battle
- 29b–57: a series of maxims, addressing the theme of how to cope with loss
- 58–72: the speaker reflects on universal themes of transience, as observed in the natural world and the world of men; maxims on how to acquire wisdom
- 73–87: the transience of worldly glory
- 88–96: Lament for the loss of the joys of the hall
- 97–110: Lament for the death of warriors and the loss of earthly things
- 111–115: maxims recommending the importance of not losing faith, nor becoming boastful or giving in to despair; the true consolation is to be found in heaven

[3] Wyrd (Fate)

Wyrd bið ful aræd (*Wanderer*, l. 5b)

[**Fate** is fully determined]

Ne mæg werig mod **wyrde** wiðstandan,
ne se hreo hyge helpe gefremman. (*Wanderer*, ll. 15–16)

[Nor may the weary mind withstand **fate**,
nor may the afflicted heart bring about help.]

Distinguishing between Fate (Wyrd) and Providence (foreponc):

Se God wunað simle on þære hean ceastre his anfealdnesse and bilewitnesses [...] Ac þæt þætte we hatað Godes foreðonc and his foresceawung, þæt bið þa hwile þe hit þærmid bið on his mode, ærþam ðe hit gefremed weorðe, þa hwile þe hit gepoht bið, ac siððan hit fullfremed bið, þonne hatað we hit **wyrd**. Be þy mæg ælc mon witan þæt hit sint ægþer ge twegen naman ge twa þing, **foreponc** and **wyrd**. Se **foreponc** is sio godcunde gesceadwisnes; sio is fæst on þam hean sceoppende þe all forewat hu hit geweorðan sceal ær ær hit geweorðe. Ac þæt þæt we **wyrd** hatað, þæt bið Godes weorc

þe he ælce dæg wƿrcð, ægþer ge þæs ðe we geseoð ge þæs þe ungesewenlic bið. Ac se godcunda foreþonc heaþerað ealle gesceafta þæt hi ne moton toslupan of heora [endebyrdnesse]. (Old English Boethius, ed. Godden and Irvine, 1, p. 362, ll. 118-32.)

[Wisdom: “[...] That God dwells always in the high city of his singleness and simplicity [...]. But that which we call God’s providence and his fore-seeing, that exists for the time that it is there in his mind, before it is effected, while it is thought, but after it is effected then we call it **fate**. From this everyone can perceive that they are both two names and two things, **providence and fate**. **Providence** is the divine intelligence; it is fixed in the high creator who fore-knows all, how it must turn out before it happens. But that which we call **fate**, that is God’s work which he effects every day, both that which we see and that which is invisible. But the divine providence restrains all creatures so that they may not slip from their ordering. [...]”] (*Old English Boethius*, ed. and trans. Godden and Irvine, 2, p. 82.)

[4] Bede, *Historia Ecclesiastica* II.xii, the exile of King Edwin of Northumbria:

Cum persequente illum Aedilfrido, qui ante eum regnauit, per diuersa occultus loca uel regna multo annorum tempore profugus uagaretur, tandem uenit ad Redualdum, obsecrans ut uitam suam a tanti persecutoris insidiis tutando seruaret. Qui libenter eum excipiens promisit se quae petebatur esse facturum.

[When he was being persecuted by his predecessor Æthelfrith, he wandered secretly as a fugitive for many years through many places and kingdoms, until at last he came to Rædwald and asked him for protection against the plots of his powerful persecutor. Rædwald received him gladly, promising to do what he asked.]

[5] Exiled at sea, *The Seafarer*, ll. 1–12:

Mæg ic be me sylfum soð-gied wrecan,
 sipas secgan, hu ic geswinc-dagum
 earfoð-hwile oft þrowade,
 bitre breost-ceare gebiden hæbbe,
 gecunnad in ceole cear-selda fela,
 atol yþa gewealc, þær mec oft bigeat
 nearo niht-waco æt nacan stefnan,
 þonne he be clifum cnossað. Calde geprungen
 wæron mine fet, forste gebunden,
 caldum clommum, þær þa ceare seofedun
 hat ymb heortan; hungor innan slat
 mere-werges mod.

[I can recite a true song about myself, relate my experiences, how in days of toil I have often suffered times of hardship, endured bitter breast care, known in my ship many an abode of care, the terrible tossing of the waves, where the anxious night-watch often held me at the ship’s prow, when, oppressed by cold, the ship tosses along the cliffs. My feet were frozen, bound by frost, by cold fetters, where those cares sighed hot around my heart; hunger from within tore the spirit of the sea-weary one.] (trans. Bjork, p. 29)

[6] Sorrow and Sleep

Ðonne sorg ond slæp somod ætgædre
 earmne anhogan oft gebindað. (*Wanderer* ll. 39-40)

[Then sorrow and sleep both together often bind the wretched solitary]

***Beowulf*, l. 119:**

sorge ne cuðon, swefan æfter symble

[They did not know sorrow, asleep after the feast]

***Phoenix*, l. 56a:**

ne sorg ne slæp [neither sorrow nor sleep]

***Solomon and Saturn II*, l. 135:**

Sorg bið swarost byrðen, slæp bið deaðe gelicost.

[Sorrow is the heaviest burden, sleep is most like death].

[7] Walls and Ruins

‘Ongietan sceal gleaw hæle hu gæstlic bið,
 þonne ealre þisse worulde wela weste stondeð,
 swa nu missenlice geond þisne middangeard
 winde biwaune weallas stondaþ,
 hrim bihrorene, hryðge þa ederas. (*Wanderer* ll. 73-77)

[‘The wise man must understand how ghastly it will be when all the riches of this world stand waste as now variously throughout this world walls stand, blown by wind, covered by frost, buildings exposed to storms.]

Ypde swa þisne eard-geard ælda scyppend
 oþþæt burg-wara breahtra lease
 eald enta geweorc idlu stodon. (*Wanderer*, ll. 85-87)

[So the Creator of Men laid waste this dwelling place, until deprived of the noise of the city dwellers, the ancient work of giants stood empty.]

***Ruin*, ll. 1-2:**

Wrætlic is þes wealstan, wyrde gebræcon;
 burgstede burston, broснаð enta geweorc.

[The wall-stone is wonderful, broken by fate, the settlements burst open, the work of giants decays]

***Maxims II*, 1b-3a:**

Ceastra beoð feorran gesyne,
 orðanc enta geweorc, þa þe on þysse eorðan syndon,
 wrætlic weallstana geweorc.

[Cities may be seen from afar, the skilled work of giants, those that are on this earth, wondrous work of wall-stones.]

[8] Ways of dying and Beasts of Battle

Sume wig fornom,
 ferede in forð-wege, sumne fugel opbær
 ofer heanne holm, sumne se hara wulf
 deaðe gedælde, sumne dreorig-hleor
 in eorð-scræfe eorl gehydde. (*Wanderer*, 18b–24)

[Some battle took away, carried on the way forth, some the bird bore off over the deep sea, some the grey wolf severed in death, some sad-faced one hid a warrior in an earth cave.]

Fortunes of Men, ll. 15–24a:

Sumne sceal hungor ahipan, sumne sceal hreoh fordripan,
 sumne sceal gar agetan, sumne guð abreotan.
 Sum sceal leomena leas lifes neotan,
 folmum ætfeohtan, sum on feðe lef,
 seono-bennum seoc, sar cwanian,
 murnan meotud-gesceaft mode gebysgad.
 Sum sceal on holte of hean beame
 fiperleas feallan;

[Hunger will destroy one; rough weather will drive one off; A spear will pour one's blood out; battle will destroy one. One must live his life lightless, grope about with his hands; one, lame of foot, sick with sinew wounds, troubled in mind, will lament his pain, mourn the decrees of fate. One will fall from a high tree in the forest, featherless.] (trans. Bjork, pp. 57–9)

Arnórr jarlaskáld Þórðarson, *Magnússdrápa*, st. 15:

Sveins manna rekr sunnan
 sǫndug lík at strǫndum;
 vítt sér ǫld, fyr útan
 Jótland hvar hræ fljóta.
 Vitnir dregr ór vatni
 (vann Óleifs sonr bannat)
 — búk slítr vargr í víkum —
 valkǫst (ara fǫstu).

[Sandy corpses of Sveinn's men are cast from the south onto the beaches; far and wide people see where bodies float off Jylland. The wolf drags a heap of slain from the water; {Óláfr's son} [= Magnús] made fasting forbidden for the eagle; the wolf tears a corpse in the bays.] (ed. and trans. Diana Whaley [2009])

***Y Gododdin* st 6:**

Kynt y gic e vleid nogyt e neithyawr.
 Kynt e vud e vran nogyt e allawr.

[Sooner meat for wolves than the marriage feast, sooner a benefit to ravens than to the altar]

[9] Ubi sunt?

Hwær cwom mearg? Hwær cwom mago? Hwær cwom mappum-gyfa?
 Hwær cwom symbla gesetu? Hwær sindon sele-dreamas?
 Eala beorht bune! Eala byrn-wiga!
 Eala þeodnes þrym! Hu seo þrag gewat,
 genap under niht-helm, swa heo no wære. (*Wanderer* ll. 92-96)

[Where is the horse? Where is the kinsman? Where is the treasure giver? Where are the seats of feasting? Where are the joys of the hall? Alas for the bright cup! Alas the mail-coated warrior! Alas the glory of the prince! How that time passed away, grew dark under the helmet of night, as if it had never been.]

[10] Life is loaned

Her bið feoh læne, her bið freond læne,
 her bið mon læne, her bið mæg læne,
 eal þis eorþan gesteal idel weorpeð (*Wanderer* ll. 108-10)

[Here wealth is fleeting, here a friend is fleeting, here a man is fleeting, here a kinsman is fleeting; all this earthen foundation will become empty.]

Hávamál st. 76

Deyr fé, deyja frændr,
 deyr sjálfr it sama;
 en orðstírr deyr aldregi
 hveim er sér góðan getr.

[Cattle die, kinsmen die, one dies oneself the same. But renown will never die for whoever gets himself a good one.]

[11] Stability in Heaven

Swa cwæð snottor on mode, gesæt him sundor æt rune.
 Til biþ se þe his treowe gehealdeþ, ne sceal næfre his torn to rycene
 beorn of his breostum acypan, nemþe he ær þa bote cunne,
 eorl mid elne gefremman. Wel bið þam þe him are seceð,
 frofre to fæder on heofonum, þær us eal seo fæstnung stondeð.
 (*Wanderer*, ll. 111-15)

[So spoke the wise one in his mind, sat himself apart in meditation. It will be good for the one that keeps his faith, nor shall he reveal his grief to quickly, the man to make it known from his breast, unless he already knows the remedy, the man to bring it about with courage. It will be well for the one that seeks consolation, the comfort of the Father in the heavens, where for all of us the stronghold stands.]

[12] A transformative reading

When the wanderer sits himself sundor æt rune [...] he actively embraces his lot, thus turning the relatively helpless anhaga, trapped in his earthly, cultural surroundings, into the sage who transforms the inferior, world-bound, essentially hopeless exile track of the Germanic warrior world into the superior, heaven bound, hope-filled exile track of the Christian faith. (Bjork, 'Sundor æt rune', p. 324.)

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